

PHONE QUALITY

Phones have full-fledged manual mode, and some even shoot in RAW! In some cases the quality is pretty comparable to that of a DSLR. Phonearena recently did a face-off between the Samsung Galaxy S8, The Panasonic GH4 and The Nikon D5100. Although the cameras won, the S8 put up a good fight (<http://digit.in/S8vs2KCam>). Chase Jarvis, an award-winning photographer who wrote a book about iPhone photography once said, “The best camera is the one that you have with you.”

CREATIVE PHOTOGRAPHY

New innovations in technology have given cameras the ability to see more than just the visual spectrum. Lytro and its light field cameras have been heralded as the next big revolution in photography since digitization. For the uninformed, a light-field camera captures the light field emanating from the scene. Where a conventional camera records only the intensity of light, the light field camera records the direction of propagation as well. This translates to the photograph carrying enough information about the scene to be able to change the depth of field later. This gives power to the photographer as an artist. Lytro's webgl player allows the viewer to refocus the photos, interactively. This medium brings photography to the realm of interactive arts, an art form where the audience themselves are part of the artwork. The photographer, for instance could convey two stories where each story is revealed when the viewer focuses on a different point. Check out 500px's lytro section for examples of art made with Lytro cameras.

Other innovations like 360-degree photography and Drones widen the camera's perspective as well as the photographer's. Red Bull may not actually give you wings, but drones do. They enable the photographer to go where physical limitations don't allow her/him to. VR is a new way to experience photography, and it's purely a technology innovation.

SOFTWARE IS STILL ART

From the late 19th century to the early 20th century, photography observed an art movement called pictorialism. It was during this period that photography was realized as a fine art. This movement saw photographers, rather than depicting reality as is, give the photograph a few artistic tweaks to give it a surreal feel. Some of the tweaks included using different hues like sepia or cyan compared to the usual black and white, making changes to the surface of the photograph and inserting



Julia Cameron's tweaked pictorialism art

brush strokes manually in post production. Julia Cameron's photograph titled, “Angel of the Nativity”, (pictured above) is an excellent example of pictorialism.

All that software does is move this philosophy to digital photography – either in camera or the help of software. Instead of using physical processes to add effects, we use photo-editing applications like Photoshop. Even Instagram-like filters fall under this category, and phones come with inbuilt filters that can be applied on the fly. Purists will scoff at these photos and label them not art, but I think that's unfair. They're just different forms of art. It's like purists complaining that Picasso or Cubism isn't art. They're just a different type of art, that's all. Technology is really just elevating and diversifying the art form of photography as a whole.

BOTTOMLINE

I don't think photography is a dying artform. I think standards are evolving, innovation is driving change, and everyone getting a capable camera in their pocket is resulting in diversity of ideas like never before. Personally I hate the idea of selfies and snapchat and neither do I like modern art, but who am I to proclaim that they're not art? As long as there are people who appreciate something and call it art; it's art. Period. An art can die, but only if the means to the art, die. In all other cases, it evolves. Photography and cameras aren't going anywhere, and as long as we're clicking photos, the art of photography can never, ever, die. **4**